



READY TO DIE
Japanese pilots (left) prepare spiritually for a one-way mission. Despite the intended outcome of their missions, each pilot carried a survival kit (below).



The fleet carrier *Hiyo* was sunk and a number of other ships damaged for the loss of only a handful of American aircraft. Exhausted by the anxiety and exhilaration of combat, the airmen then faced the challenge of reaching home – a small flight deck far off in a vast, dark ocean. Soon aircraft began running out of fuel and ditching in the sea. To help those with enough gas find their way back, Mitscher ordered the fleet to “turn on the lights,” setting everything from searchlights to star shells ablaze in the utter darkness – a courageous action in submarine-infested waters. Some tired pilots flying into the blinding light show found it impossible to locate a carrier and ditched in the middle of the fleet. Some finally ran out of fuel within sight of a flight deck. In all, about 80 aircraft were lost in the oceans, although happily

four out of five aircrews were rescued.

Japanese naval aviation never recovered from the huge losses of aircraft and pilots at the Battle of the Philippine Sea. The Battle of Leyte Gulf the following October was the largest naval encounter in history, and one of the most dramatic. But from the viewpoint of carrier warfare it was a crushing walkover. The Japanese carriers were short of airplanes, incapable of

“We are 16 warriors manning the bombers. May our death be as sudden and clean as the shattering of crystal!”

JAPANESE KAMIKAZE PILOT

launching a penetrating strike against the US fleet or defending themselves against mass attacks by US Navy aircraft. By the end of the battle, the entire Japanese carrier fleet had been destroyed. In a last effort to provide air cover for her fleet, Japan launched the 80,633-ton (73,150-tonne) *Shinano* in November 1944, the largest carrier in the world; it was sunk by an American submarine 17 hours into its maiden voyage.

FUTILE SACRIFICE

A Japanese fighter aircraft on a suicide mission is shot down by US Navy anti-aircraft guns. The majority of kamikaze missions ended like this – without inflicting damage on Allied warships.

